

Our Faithful God

Dan Birkholz · Cross of Grace Church Chaska, Chaska, MN · October 4, 2026

Series: Our Faithful God

Ruth 1:1-5 PRIMARY TEXT	32 min SERMON LENGTH	23 SCRIPTURE REFERENCES	31 SECTIONS WE MAPPED
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THE SERMON IN ONE SENTENCE

God's hidden but meticulous providence in our suffering should lead us to active trust in His goodness rather than compromise of His promises, because He is orchestrating redemption in ways that extend far beyond our immediate circumstances or even our lifetimes.

Summary

Dan Birkholz opens a series on Ruth by examining the book's stark beginning: famine in Bethlehem during the era of the judges, followed by a family's disastrous sojourn in Moab. Rather than a once-upon-a-time idyll, Ruth opens in catastrophe—yet beneath the surface, God's hidden hand is meticulously orchestrating events that will lead to David and ultimately to Christ. The sermon draws two lessons from Ruth 1:1-5: first, never underestimate God's providence in suffering—He sees you, knows you by name, and never wastes pain, working purposes that extend far beyond your lifetime; second, never compromise God's promises even when circumstances make it feel reasonable—Elimelech's move to Moab shows the trajectory of compromise (temporary becomes permanent, suffering follows). Like the father in the prodigal son parable, God longs for us to come home to the land of promise and walk the narrow way of faithfulness, trusting His steadfast love even in famine.

YOUR SERMON PAGE

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/CrossOfGraceChaska/sermons/our-faithful-god-2026-10-04>

THIS WEEK ACROSS THE REGION

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/MidwestNorthwest/10-4-26/>

Eight Sovereign Grace churches, one Sunday: Scripture, themes, and How We Said It.

What We Noticed

Doctrinal loci

- **Providence / Sovereignty** — The sermon's first major lesson centers on God's hidden but meticulous providence orchestrating Ruth's suffering toward David and Christ, arguing that God never wastes pain and works purposes beyond our lifetimes.
- **Covenant Theology** — The exposition grounds Elimelech's compromise in leaving the land of promise and connects the famine to Deuteronomy 28 covenant curses, reading the whole narrative through God's covenantal faithfulness despite Israel's failure.
- **Sanctification** — The sermon's second lesson addresses the temptation to compromise God's promises under pressure, calling believers to walk the narrow way of faithfulness and endure suffering without moral compromise.
- **Christology** — The climactic move of the exposition reveals that Ruth's suffering leads to Christ—the Bread of Life born in Bethlehem who became a curse so we might know blessing—making Him the ultimate telos of providential suffering.

Themes

God's hidden providence in suffering

The danger of compromising under pressure

Trusting God's goodness when life is hard

Generational faithfulness and legacy

Coming home to God's promises

Editor notes

- The sermon features an unusually transparent pastoral aside (units 1-5) where Birkholz explicitly names his measurable goals for the series—active trust, sacrificial friendship, verbal blessing, and generational vision—creating accountability and inviting congregational ownership.
- The rhetorical structure effectively moves from macro to micro: centuries of darkness in the judges era narrows to one family's story, then zooms back out to cosmic significance (David, then Christ), demonstrating providence across scale.

- The strongest theological move is the deliberate interpretive caveat in unit 27—noting that the text withholds stating Naomi's losses are divine punishment in order to cultivate longing rather than self-righteousness, protecting pastoral application from moralism.
- The prodigal son illustration powerfully reframes the entire Moab episode not as a story about divine retribution but about the Father's longing for the compromised to come home, shifting the emotional register from warning to invitation.

Writing Prompts

Concepts from each main point you could explore further in your own reading and writing.

1. When Your Story Starts in the Middle of Disaster

Ruth's opening challenges the assumption that faithful lives begin or unfold in peace. For those whose lives have never known serenity or whose suffering has consumed memory of past goodness, Scripture gives a story that starts where you are—and shows God's hidden hand already at work in the darkness.

FROM: UNITS 8-10, THE CONTRAST BETWEEN TYPICAL NARRATIVE OPENINGS AND RUTH'S OPENING IN DISASTER

2. God Does Not Waste Your Suffering

Ruth's pointless-seeming losses produced David and ultimately Christ—purposes she never lived to see. This pattern reveals a crucial truth for believers in hard times: God's providence extends beyond our comprehension and even our lifetimes, orchestrating redemption on a scale we cannot measure from inside our pain.

FROM: UNITS 15-19, THE EXPOSITION OF GOD'S METICULOUS PROVIDENCE FROM ONE FAMILY'S SUFFERING TO THE INCARNATION

3. How Hard Times Reframe Moral Decisions as Practical Ones

Elimelech didn't set out to compromise—he faced a famine and made what looked like a reasonable survival decision. But naming God as king while leaving the land of promise reveals the pattern: pressure tempts us to reclassify obedience as impractical. The exhortation remains: don't compromise God's promises, no matter how ethical the alternative feels.

FROM: UNITS 21-23, ELIMELECH'S DECISION TO GO TO MOAB AND THE REFRAMING OF MORAL DECISIONS UNDER PRESSURE

4. The Trajectory of Compromise: Temporary, Settled, Entrenched

Ruth's text tracks Elimelech's progression with precision: sojourn becomes remained becomes ten years. It's the familiar arc of moral drift—what we tell ourselves is temporary becomes the new normal, then calcifies into identity. Recognizing the pattern is the first step toward resistance.

FROM: UNIT 24, THE TEXTUAL PROGRESSION OF COMPROMISE FROM SOJOURN TO REMAINING TO TEN YEARS

5. When the Text Withholds Judgment

Ruth deliberately does not say Naomi's losses were punishment for leaving the land. This authorial restraint is pastoral genius: it protects readers from self-righteous judgment while cultivating the longing God Himself has—for the compromised to come home. Not every tragedy comes with a moral explanation, but every tragedy comes with an invitation.

FROM: UNIT 27, THE INTERPRETIVE CAVEAT ABOUT THE TEXT'S SILENCE ON DIVINE PUNISHMENT

6. The Father Watching the Horizon

The prodigal son parable reframes the entire Moab narrative: God is not the angry judge waiting to punish the backslider, but the Father scanning the road, longing for return. For believers in compromise or unbelievers far from home, the posture of God is not vindictive distance but aching love. The question is whether we'll come home.

FROM: UNIT 28, THE PRODIGAL SON ILLUSTRATION APPLIED TO NAOMI'S SITUATION AND THE CONGREGATION'S

7. The Glory of the Narrow Way

Jesus promised the path would be narrow, difficult, and unpopular—He never promised ease to those who follow Him. But the glory isn't in the width of the road; it's in walking the yes and amen of all God's promises, held by Christ Himself until He ends every sorrow. Faithfulness under pressure isn't grim endurance; it's glorious trust.

FROM: UNIT 29, THE APPLICATION OF JESUS' TEACHING ON THE NARROW WAY TO THOSE WEARY BUT NOT YET COMPROMISED

Congregation Resources

The same resources published on your sermon page.

Small-Group Discussion

When Ruth opens with famine, death, and the spiritual darkness of the judges' era rather than peace and security, what does this tell us about the kind of God we worship and the kind of world He permits His people to inhabit?

↳ How does this opening shape the way you read the rest of Ruth's story—what posture does it invite from us as readers?

RUTH 1:1-5

Elimelech's decision to leave Bethlehem for Moab began as what seemed like a temporary, practical solution to suffering. What does his trajectory—from temporary to permanent—reveal about how compromise under pressure typically unfolds in our own lives?

↳ Can you think of a time when a 'temporary' compromise became something more permanent? What spiritual patterns do you notice looking back?

RUTH 1:1-2; LUKE 15:11-32

The sermon emphasizes that God's providence is 'hidden but meticulous' in Ruth's story. What difference does it make to believe that God sees us by name and orchestrates redemption in our suffering, even when we cannot yet perceive His hand?

RUTH 1:1-5; PSALM 33:18-21

Ruth 1 shows us a family that will eventually lead to King David and ultimately to Jesus Christ—a redemptive arc that Naomi and Ruth could not have imagined in their moment of grief. How does learning that God never wastes suffering reshape your willingness to trust Him when circumstances seem only dark and pointless?

↳ What hesitations or doubts surface as you consider this? How might we hold both honest lament and active trust together?

RUTH 1:1-5; MATTHEW 1:5

The sermon connects Elimelech's compromise to the broader pattern of the judges' era—'everyone did what was right in his own eyes.' When we are tempted to compromise God's promises because circumstances make it feel 'reasonable' or 'ethical,' how do we distinguish between wisdom and unfaithfulness?

JUDGES 21:25; MATTHEW 7:13

As we look at the applications—active trust cultivated through communal prayer, sacrificial friendship as a sign of God's faithfulness, and verbal blessings as intercessory declarations—which of these practices is most absent from our common life together, and what would it cost us to restore it?

↳ How might one concrete act of these practices this week become a tangible expression of belief in God's faithfulness?

Daily Readings

This week we trace God's hidden providence through Ruth's opening darkness, learning that He never wastes suffering, that compromise under pressure carries lasting consequences, and that active trust in His goodness is our glad response to His faithfulness.

Monday Judges 21:25

In Judges, Israel spirals into moral chaos and self-will precisely because they have abandoned covenant faithfulness. Ruth opens into this same cultural moment of spiritual blindness and disorder. Yet even here—in an era when God's guidance seems most obscured—His hand orchestrates redemption with perfect precision, teaching us that our darkest circumstances are never beyond His sight or purpose.

Tuesday Psalm 33:18-21

The psalmist declares that 'the eye of the Lord is on those who fear Him, on those whose hope is in His steadfast love,' and promises that His soul is kept alive by His provision. Naomi and Ruth, in their famine and bereavement, could not see how their pain was being woven into the lineage of David and ultimately Christ. Yet the eye of the Lord sees the end from the beginning, and His purposes extend far beyond our immediate view—our suffering is never meaningless, even when meaning is hidden from us.

Wednesday Luke 15:11-32

Elimelech's move to Moab began as a reasonable response to famine—a practical survival decision—but it became a permanent departure from the land of covenant promise. The prodigal son's journey to the far country mirrors this pattern: each step feels justified in the moment, each compromise reasonable. Yet the Father's heart longs for his return, not to condemn but to restore. We are called to the narrow way of faithfulness, even when the broader path of compromise seems kinder to ourselves in our suffering.

Thursday Genesis 19

Lot's choice to dwell in Sodom began as a strategic move toward material advantage, yet it led his family into moral compromise and spiritual danger. Similarly, Elimelech's departure to Moab—a land outside God's covenant promise, inhabited by a people hostile to Israel—was presented as temporary survival, yet it became the setting for his death and the deepening of Naomi's despair. Our choices in hard times do not remain isolated; they shape the spiritual inheritance we leave and the circumstances in which our faith is tested across the years.

Friday Matthew 7:13

Jesus teaches that 'the gate is narrow and the way is hard that leads to life.' Naomi and Ruth, having turned from the detour of Moab and returned to Bethlehem, walked the narrow path of faithfulness under apparent destitution—yet this is precisely where God's redemptive purposes were being fulfilled. We too are invited to trust that God's promises, though costly and often obscured by suffering, lead to life and blessing in ways our circumstances cannot yet reveal. Our glad response is to remain faithful, together, as a community of those who have seen His goodness.

Memory Verse

Behold, the eye of the LORD is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his steadfast love, that he may deliver their soul from death and keep them alive in famine. Our soul waits for the LORD; he is our help and our shield. For our heart is glad in him, because we trust in his holy name.

— *Psalm 33:18-21*

This passage captures the sermon's central claim that God's hidden but meticulous providence sustains us through suffering, and that active trust in His goodness—rather than compromise—is the proper response. It directly anchors the exhortation to rest in God's faithfulness even when famine and hardship make compromise feel reasonable.

Family Conversation

When Life Doesn't Feel Like Home

In the story we heard today, Naomi's family left their home in Bethlehem because there wasn't enough food. It seemed like the right thing to do at the time. But God had promised to take care of His people in that land. If you were Naomi, what would have been the hardest part about staying in Bethlehem when everything felt so difficult? And what might it mean to trust God even when staying feels impossible?

WORKS FOR AGES 8+

For parents: This prompt invites your family to reflect on the opening scene of Ruth—a family forced to leave their home because of famine. Help your children think about times when circumstances have pushed them (or people they know) to compromise or leave behind what they believed was true. The goal is to help them see that God is working even when we can't see His plan.

For Couples

God's Hidden Hand in Our Hard Times

When you heard that God is meticulously at work even in suffering we cannot see, what stirred in your heart—comfort, doubt, conviction, or something else?

Where might we, as a couple, be tempted to compromise God's promises because our circumstances make compromise feel reasonable or necessary?

What is one specific way God has shown His faithfulness to us that we could pray into each other's lives this week—something that reminds us He sees us and wastes nothing?